

THE DUST BOWL

Hunger and poverty were made worse by a series of droughts in the Great Plains, a large area of the central US. With the lack of rain, crops failed and soil turned into loose dust. Strong winds whipped this dust into storms, which covered homes and farms. The area became known as the "Dust Bowl."



The Great Depression

In October 1929, the US stock market crashed. Billions of dollars were lost, leading to the biggest economic crisis in history, known as the Great Depression. Companies went out of business, and factories were forced to close, causing millions to lose their jobs. Poverty and hunger became widespread, and the impact of the crash was soon felt across the world. It took a decade for the global economy to recover.

▲ SOUP KITCHENS

More than 10 million Americans were out of work by 1932. Private charities and church communities opened soup kitchens for the hungry and unemployed. They served soup and bread for free, and for thousands of people, these were the only places they could get a meal. By the mid-1930s the government had taken over the running of soup kitchens.

The economic boom of the 1920s had led ordinary Americans to invest in the stock market. But by 1929, economic growth had begun to slow and companies found they couldn't sell their goods. Share prices dipped, causing investors to sell their shares.

When the stock market crashed, the shares suddenly became worthless. Millionaires became poor overnight, and people who had taken loans from banks to buy houses couldn't pay them back and lost their homes. Hunger and mass unemployment raged, and slums with terrible living conditions emerged.

Meanwhile, the effect of the depression spread across the world. In Germany, poverty and unemployment led people to vote for the Nazi Party, which promised a way out—leading, in time, to World War II (see pp.190–191).

NEW DEAL ►

Franklin D. Roosevelt became president of the US on the promise of a "new deal," which would help the country's economy to recover. From 1933 to 1939, his government introduced policies that helped people find work again. Many projects, such as the construction of the massive Hoover Dam (right), were started to create more jobs.

